

Analysing (political) speeches

(Political) speeches, eg by American presidents, British prime ministers or other influential people are usually carefully crafted – each word is deliberately chosen. For your analysis you usually only get a part of the speech (an excerpt).

Political speeches often aim at...

- **raising awareness** of a certain issue/ problem (e.g. climate change, street violence etc.)
- **sharing and promoting a vision** (e.g. for the country's future, a presidency)
- **convincing** listeners (e.g. of political ideas or that he/she is the right candidate)
- **challenging** listeners (to become involved, to change a certain policy or behavior)

Often there is a **mixture** of these. You need to have some socio-political **background knowledge**, eg about political events or ideas like the American Dream in order to be able to analyse the speech properly.

Context of the speech

Before you analyse anything, you should consider the context of the speech. The aim of a victory speech after an election can be very different from the purpose of a speech given after a school shooting! Ask yourself...



Who is talking – not just his/her name, but also his/her **role** at that time (as president/ business man...)



When was the speech given? What's the **occasion**? Was it just before an election? After an important event?



Where was the speech given? In the United States? Another country? In a church? In a stadium?...



To whom? What audience? Supporters or "enemies"? Politicians or common people? Academics or workers?



With which aims? To thank people? To challenge them to do sth? To convince, inspire, encourage... them?



On what topic? E.g. his/her plans for the future, sharing a vision, discussing an important topic

Example of an introduction: *The excerpt from Senator Barack Obama's political speech "Change We Can Believe In", his Democratic Nomination Victory speech, delivered on June 3rd, 2008 in St. Paul, Minnesota, aims to prove to the audience that he is the right candidate for the presidential election in 2008 and defines his goals and beliefs. ...*

Typical structure / line of argument

1. A political speech generally starts with an **introduction** by which the speaker intends to attract the audience's attention, for example by
 - making clear the purpose of the speech
 - mentioning the topic and by emphasizing its importance
 - beginning with a question or a little story
 - pointing out a problem / recent trend/ dilemma/ a popular opinion
 - showing or referring to something related to the topic, such as an object, a photo, statistics, etc.
2. In the **main part** of the speech the speaker tries to develop his main idea further, for example by
 - developing his/her thoughts and main points step by step
 - backing up his/her main ideas/points with facts and background information
 - suggesting what should be done to improve the situation or presenting solutions to the problem
 - including personal experience, examples or a story to make his/her speech more lively, establish a "personal" relationship to become well-liked
 - using rhetorical and stylistic devices to maintain the audience's attention (↓ *see below*)
3. **At the end of his/her speech** the speaker often makes an (emotional) appeal, e.g. by
 - summing up his/her main ideas/arguments in one or two sentences
 - briefly mentioning what the outlook might be
 - asking the audience to support his view, ideas, program, etc.
 - challenging the listeners to do sth ("call for action")

Language help for outlining a structure:

- ▶ The speaker/ [name of speaker] starts off with/ begins with/...
- ▶ provides several arguments/ facts for...
- ▶ compares... with.../ criticizes/ illustrates/...
- ▶ claims/ states [behauptet]
- ▶ concedes/admits that... but then argues/ refutes...
- ▶ demands [fordert]
- ▶ challenges/ criticizes/ questions the idea of...
- ▶ promises
- ▶ focuses on
- ▶ provides (background) information about
- ▶ suggests/ offers solution to/for
- ▶ concludes by suggesting.../ reaffirming/



Many speeches **start with a specific** example/event/ story and **then present** the problem/ idea **on a more general level**.

Communicative strategies / rhetorical devices/ techniques

- ▶ **use of pronouns**
 - **inclusive language** (use of **personal pronouns** such as we, us etc.) → establishes a (personal) connection, creates a sense of belonging/ unity
 - **they/them vs. we/us** – who is *they* and *we* in the context of the speech? Who is *the other*, who is not included, who seems to be the “enemy”?
 - **direct address**: e.g. you should think about... → raises awareness, forces listener to think about his/her own life, challenges listener, creates a personal connection...
 - **first-person pronoun** (I, me...): A speaker often referring to himself (I planned/ met/ talked to...) might try to come across as powerful, hard-working, responsible etc.
- ▶ giving **specific, authentic and/or current examples** e.g. a particular person who has done sth; a concrete event → to highlight the topicality of the topic; to exemplify/ illustrate a problem/trend
- ▶ sharing **personal anecdotes/ stories** (of him-/herself or of others) → establishes an emotional connection with the listener, making a general problem more relatable, making the speaker look like “down-to-earth” (“one of us”)
- ▶ **appealing to authority**: uses the opinion of an **expert** (e.g. a president) or authority figure to impress audience or prove a point, show that the speaker is well-informed
- ▶ **citing statistics/ evidence**: make writer’s argument more convincing/ credible
- ▶ **use of quotes** (often by someone famous) → to quote an authority, to sum up sth, make sth more humorous or memorable
- ▶ **providing background information**: → to show the speaker’s competence, to help the listener understand a complex topic
- ▶ use of (concrete) **details** → What are the connotations of their choice of details? (e.g. the age, hair color of a person)
- ▶ raising/posing/ asking (rhetorical) **questions** → get the listener to think (of/ about)/ reflect (on sth)
- ▶ **generalization/simplification**: A sweeping/ general statement that suggests what is true for some is true for all; → simplifies complex issues, offers simple solutions
- ▶ **making a joke** → to entertain the audience, maintain the attention, establish a connection, lighten the mood

These strategies are **often used to...**

... establish a connection with the audience , e.g. by • personal stories, inclusive pronouns • a conversational style (e.g. by using questions) • making jokes	... present ideas understandably or memorably e.g. by • using personal stories/ examples; details • simplification of a complex topic (e.g. through generalizations, omission of details or other viewpoints)
... make ideas credible & convincing So that the listener is more inclined to believe the speaker; e.g. by using... quotes, statistics, appeals to authority	... place emphasis on certain idea, increase/stress the impact of the main point e.g. by using details, examples, illustrations
... catch/maintain the listener’s attention e.g. by telling a shocking, surprising or amusing story, making a joke	... convey a certain image of the speaker Speakers often try to appear... competent (e.g. by using statistics); relatable (“one of us”); witty/ smart
... move & challenge the listener e.g. by using direct address, direct questions	

Motifs, historical references, symbols, key ideas and role models

An American president will refer to [verweisen auf]/ allude to [anspielen auf] different motifs and symbols than a German chancellor since both of them are part of different countries with different historical backgrounds. Some examples:

- American presidents often refer to **key motifs** such as the American Dream, the ideal of independence, American exceptionalism (“America is special”)...
- No matter the background, lots of speakers make **historical references** (e.g. “As the founding fathers have envisioned”, “As Lincoln famously said”). These references are often used to...
 - show the **continuation** of certain ideas into the present (and beyond);
 - to **compare** how times have changed/ how far we’ve come...
 - to highlight that **the speaker sees him-/herself as part of an idea/ a tradition**, that s/he wants to uphold key values
- Certain **symbols/ places** are used to allude to big ideas (e.g. Wall Street = place of business / finance)
- **role models** or **heroes** (often from the same country/area where the speaker speaks) are often quoted and praised to make a point or draw a connection (e.g. MLK as a role model for courage and justice)

Language (tone, syntax, choice of words, stylistic devices)

1. Syntax/ Sentence structure

- What are the sentences like? Are they simple with one or two clauses (paratactic)? Complex (hypotactic)?
 - Is there antithesis, chiasmus, parallel construction? What emotional impression do they leave?
- How a sentence is constructed affects the style and tone of a text:
 - Parallel syntax** (similarly styled phrases & sentences) creates interconnected emotions, feelings & ideas.
 - Short sentences** are punchy, intense and easy to remember (e.g. *This has to stop. Seriously.*)
 - Long sentences** are distancing, reflective, explanatory and more abstract; often a sign of education.

2. Tone

The mood or feeling of the language used by a speaker. **Examples of different tones:**

						
serious, distant, impersonal, impartial	hopeful, enthusiastic, optimistic, patriotic	humorous, ironic, witty (=geistreich)	authentic, vulnerable, emotional	concerned, worried, (pessimistic)	mocking (=lustig-machend), provocative	challenging, angry, bitter, aggressive, cynical
e.g. a finance executive giving an overview	e.g. a president sharing a positive vision	filled with jokes, understatement, puns, funny anecdotes, self-mocking humor (=author makes fun of himself), unusual language...	filled with personal stories; heartfelt; listener should feel the pain/emotions; sharing "from the heart"	full of problems, worried about the future	makes fun of others; use of sarcasm	very urgent way of speaking (e.g. "We have to change sth. NOW"; "How dare you!"; mostly negative/ judgmental words)

- A **shift/change** in tone (e.g. from *humorous* to *worried*) can be used to persuade the listener.
- Always include **evidence** (why do you think the tone is overall *mocking*?) + Include **line numbers**!

3. Word fields & choice of word

- Look for **word fields/ clusters**: Are there words used that go together? From what sphere of life are they?
 - e.g. word fields "**war**": *battle, fight, bomb...*; "**nature**": *green, rooted*; "**religion**": *pray, bless...*
 - associated meanings of word fields arouse certain feelings and associations
- Watch out for words (or phrases) that have either strong **positive** or **negative connotations** (e.g.: ⊕ exciting, unique, believe, courageous, yes, smart... ⊖ gloomy, crooked, miserable, bleak, dark, ...)
- Is he/she using overly **technical/ difficult words** (jargon) or rather simple words? Is there **colloquial language**?

4. Important stylistic devices (an incomplete list)

(A) images / figurative devices

- SIMILE**: Two (usually unrelated) things/ideas/ concepts are directly compared with each other though as or like.
- METAPHOR**: A figurative comparison without as or like. Typical examples in political speeches:
 - journey**: *When you've taken the wrong road, you don't just keep going, you change direction.* (David Cameron)
 - illness/health**: *Yesterday, Wall Street suffered its worst losses since just after 9/11.* (Barack Obama)
 - game**: *We don't have victories anymore... I beat China all the time.* (Donald Trump)
 - battle**: *The battle is now joined on many fronts. ... We are in a fight for our principles.* (George Bush)
 - nature**: *An economic hurricane has swept the world.* (Gordon Brown)
 - machines/systems**: *The system is broken. I alone can fix it.* (Donald Trump)
- PERSONIFICATIONS**: *Huge cities never sleep.* (a human quality/ action (*sleep*) is attributed to sth non-human (*a city*))
- METONYMY**: *London wants to...(London = British government). The White House declared (WH=US government). The pen is mightier than the sword. (pen= written word; sword = military power)*

(B) structural devices

- ALLITERATION** Alliteration is the repetition of a consonantal sound of two or more neighbouring words.
- ANAPHORA**: sentences start the same (*I believe in better schools. I believe in better hospitals. I believe in...*)
- ANTITHESIS/CONTRAST** *He gave everything to those who deserved it, but he did not give anything to those who were idle.* As a rhetorical figure antithesis denotes the opposing of ideas by means of grammatically parallel arrangements of words, clauses or sentences so as to produce an effective contrast.
- REPETITION** The repetition of words or phrases. Ex: *All are equal. All are free, all deserve a better chance* (Obama)

- ▶ **PARALLELISM** In parallelism two or more parts of one sentence (sometimes of two or more sentences) are given a similar form so as to give the whole a definite pattern. This symmetry tends to produce an agreeable rhythm. It can also help to bring out the point of a paragraph - to emphasize a contrast, for example, by balancing some words or parts of speech against each other.
We charge him with having broken his oath, we accuse him of having given up his people, and we censure him for having violated against the articles of the Bill of Rights.
- ▶ **TRIPLE/RULE OF THREE:** A series of three words, phrases or sentences that are parallel in structure, length and/or rhythm.
- ▶ **CLIMAX:** *There are three things that will endure: faith, hope, and love. But the greatest of these is love.* (increasing importance)

(C) devices of style and tone

- ▶ **HYPERBOLE:** exaggerations; making sth/sb bigger than it is; used ironically/ deliberately (e.g. *The only thing we have to fear is fear itself* (Roosevelt) or meant (half-)seriously (e.g. *No one loves women more than I do.* (Trump))
- ▶ **UNDERSTATEMENT:** opposite of hyperbole, often used humorously, make sth seem less important than it is
- ▶ **PUN** (Wortspiel): A play on a word that suggests a double meaning. (→ Grabs the listener's interest and attention, especially through the use of humour.; e.g. *Atheism is a non-prophet institution*)

A stylistic device can...

- engage/raise/catch/maintain the **listener's attention** (e.g. with repetitions, puns, triples)
- create a **memorable or vivid image** (e.g. with metaphors, similes, personifications); **illustrate** a situation
- make the topic/situation appear more **dramatic** (e.g. with a metaphor like *The EU is at a cliff. Will we fall?*)
- **simplify** a complex issue; offering clear-cut alternatives (e.g. contrast, antithesis)
- **entertain** the reader (e.g. through puns, hyperboles, odd metaphors)
- ... (don't just blindly apply one of these effects, look at the particular device and think about why it was used in in this context and this sentence)

Some helpful phrases for your analysis

- ▶ The speaker uses/employs/makes use of colloquial/current/common/formal/technical...
- ▶ words/phrases/expressions/language/terms
- ▶ He/she alludes to/suggests that...
- ▶ He/she draws a comparison/an analogy between ...
- ▶ He / she compares / contrasts A with B
- ▶ The speaker uses images/examples/metaphors/ personification ... to convey a lively/vivid/ graphic / impression
- ▶ The function/aim/ purpose/effect of ... is to...
- ▶ The intention behind this ... is to ...
- ▶ The speaker uses/ makes use of/ employs this device in order to...
- ▶ By using this device, the speakers hopes/tries to achieve ...
- ▶ This device serves/helps ...
- ▶ He/she illustrates his/her argumentation by...
- ▶ He/she repeats .../uses repetition/alliteration/ analogies to underline/stress/underscore that...
- ▶ He / she criticizes (sth in an ironical way) / attacks sb ... His/her criticism/irony is directed against/ attacks ...

⚠ Final tips

- ▶ Have a good look at the **task** you are given – what aspects of the speech you are asked to examine (→ operators). Usually this is done with reference to the intention of the speaker or the effect of the speech on the audience.
- ▶ Keep it **simple, clear & logical**. Don't just add up a list of random devices, but focus on those that seem relevant, important and powerful and explain them and their effect well. Be brave enough to think for yourself! ☺
- ▶ **Group your insights carefully and logically**. Don't just analyse the text line-by-line
 - Let's say you found a metaphor in l. 3 and in l. 29 and an anaphora in l. 15. What do you do? → First, analyse the metaphors and their use and then continue with the anaphora.
- ▶ **Use paragraphs!** Each analytical aspect should be dealt with in one paragraph (e.g. tone= 1 paragraph)
- ▶ **Use the simple present** when referring to the speech and don't forget the **-s** (*Obama praises_s, Trump claims_s*)
- ▶ **Quote properly**.
 - **comma** after says/claims, **quotation marks** on top, **I.** = 1 line; **II.** 2 or more lines; e.g. *He claims, "..."* (II. 2-3)
 - **Integrate** your quotes properly into your sentence (*His frequent use of the word "vision" (l. 2) shows...*)
- ▶ **End your analysis with a conclusion:** What is most striking about the speech? Summarise your most important analytical findings (e.g. his humorous tone, his vivid language, her use of personal stories...) and their effect